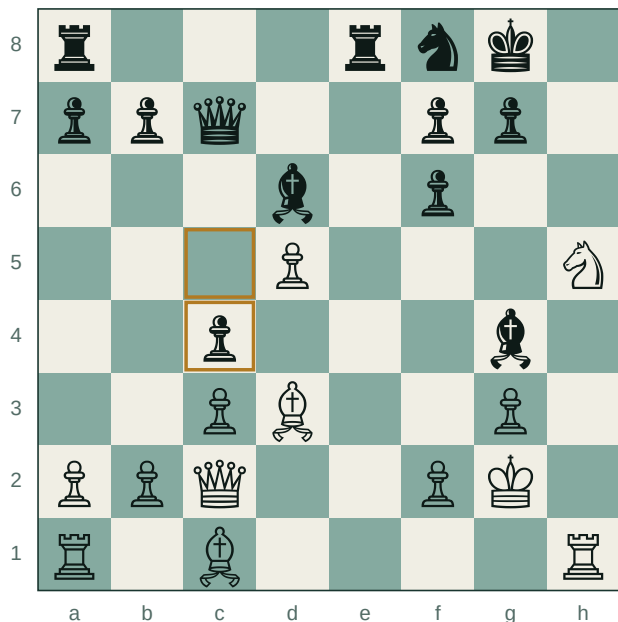


Calculated sacrifices: White, move 18

Calculated sacrifices

White to move



Previous move: 17...c4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18. Nxf6+ gxh6 19. Bh7+ Nxh7 20. Qxh7+

18.Nxf6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From f6 it attacks king on g8, rook on e8 and bishop on g4.
Recorded reply: **18...gxf6**.

19.Bh7+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **19...Nxh7**.

20.Qxh7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the knight on h7.

At the end, nominal material is White 28 / Black 30 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by -2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -2: the balance goes from +0 to -2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attractive attacking picture is not compensation by itself. Continue until the resulting position can be evaluated honestly.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A sacrifice exchanges material for a concrete benefit. The benefit may be mate, a stronger attack, a recovered investment, or lasting activity; it must be shown through moves.

HOW TO LOOK

State what the sacrifice changes: a defender, a line, a king square, or a critical tempo. Calculate acceptance and plausible refusal.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on g4. Check for tactical protection.